

Liminality Mechanisms: the *Fold*, the *Grid*, and the *Void*

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Introduction

Ever since the A24 movie *The Backrooms*, directed by Kane Parsons, was released earlier this year, the obsession with liminality has moved from semi-underground web lore into the mainstream. The lore began with a single image posted to 4chan's /x/ board, in a thread asking for "disquieting images" that felt "off." A reply to that image started the now-iconic narrative: "If you're not careful and you noclip out of reality in the wrong areas, you'll end up in the Backrooms..." The image showed a room with mono yellow wallpaper, damp carpet, and neon lights. In Mark Fisher's sense, the image was very *eerie*. The eerie term is tied to agency and presence, a failure of presence or a failure of absence. The image is a perfect example of failure of presence, human-built architecture stripped of human life. This has become the fundamental narrative of internet horrors, now called *creepypastas*.

Apparently, though, this emptiness was not uncanny enough, so the liminal space was graced with the "entities" lurking in foggy corridors. A desperate move to translate an unsettling failure of presence into a far more conventional, consumable failure of absence. This transformation functioned through what folklorists call *ostension*, the active, real-world enactment of digital legends (Andrew Peck documented this in his study of the Slender Man legend cycle). People didn't just read the lore online, they participated in it live by searching for spaces such as abandoned malls, empty transit stations, and basements, and tried to simulate the experience. No entities in sight, mind you, but dopamine was skyrocketing. On TikTok, the phenomenon evolved even further, drifting away from the quiet emptiness of early creepypastas into hyper-specific monster taxonomies and, ultimately, cinematic hype.

Beneath this digital folklore lies what Anthony Vidler calls the *architectural uncanny*, an extension of Freud's *unheimlich* (the familiar made unfamiliar) into modern built environments. The Backrooms take the most banal spaces of late capitalism such as the corporate office, the hotel corridor, the transit hub, and strip them of their function. But, these environments also carry a specific nostalgia. Svetlana Boym (in *The Future of Nostalgia*, 2001) distinguishes *restorative nostalgia*, which rebuilds the lost home and raises a rigid fictional lore around it, from *reflective nostalgia*, which lingers in the disorienting, fragmented ruins of space and time. The Backrooms and the internet hype behind them are pure examples of restorative nostalgia. They turn a living, disorienting experience into a backdrop and the subject into a helpless victim in a video-game maze. It's important to note that this physical architecture of the liminal is only the surface level of the experience. What initially drew me to these transitional, in-between spaces, rather than

their architecture, was what happens to the mind inside the space where you're liberated from the accumulated weight of context.

Five years ago, while spending hours in a daily commute, I noticed something about my thinking process. The subterranean transit system, an environment explicitly built for efficiency, crowded with exhausted commuters and deeply anti-human in its concrete design, turned out to be my most fertile creative territory. It was where the entire concept for my first exhibition was born. In the subterranean, somewhere in-between stations, I was existing inside a moving *creation chamber*. This realization also followed a crucial frustration as the second I stepped off the train and re-emerged onto the street, the creative energy collapsed. I was dropped right back into the default simulation of my daily life.

Why do transitional spaces produce this sudden surge of creative agency?

Anthropologist Marc Augé called these transitional corridors *non-places*, zones where local history and personal identity disappear, leaving you anonymous. He identified this as modern alienation. I think what Augé labeled as a "tragic loss of identity" is actually a liberating space. In these spaces no one knows what category you belong to. You can move without being fully legible, abandoning a pre-fixed state. Or in the language of Deleuze and Guattari, the pre-fixed state is called *striated space*. Modern life is relentlessly organized into rigid grids, mandated roles and schedules. Stepping into in-between states is an unintentional line of flight out of that pre-fixed grid. Transit cuts through striated space to open up a temporary pocket of what they call a *smooth space* (*A Thousand Plateaus*, 1440). For a certain amount of time, between point A and point B, you are "off the grid".

This also reveals the central paradox of transit infrastructure. These zones are hyper-designed for humans, yet fundamentally anti-human. A subway corridor or an airport boarding gate treats the individual not as a person but as an abstract unit of flow, a piece of friction to be routed from point A to point B as efficiently as possible. This systemic indifference is what liberates us, being reduced to anonymous mass produces unexpectedly radical relief. Yet, the architecture should be looked at only as a trigger for this state of mind. Hallways, transit hubs and the rest of the non-places are not the liminal experience itself but just a physical level of the internal operation. To understand the mechanism(s) of liminality, we have to look past the physical and examine what is happening beneath the surface, where this state fundamentally disrupts our identity.

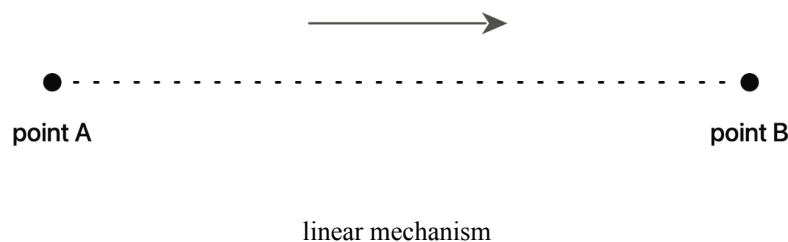
The Mechanism(s)

When we try to imagine how these transitional spaces actually operate, the initial intuition almost always drags us towards the linear. You enter at point A and leave the fixed social role,

travel through a corridor, and exit at point B as a subtly altered person, with new status and identity. Classic anthropology (starting with Victor Turner) treated this phenomenon as a simplified structured bridge. However, this linear model treats the liminal as just an instrument designed to carry you from one fixed state to another, as a secondary temporary bridge rather than an active, self-contained mechanism. We must move past Turner's view in order to understand how this mechanism actually can't be treated as linear or purely transitional.

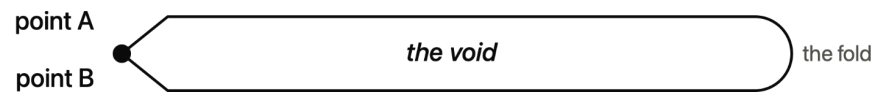
The anxiety surrounding the in-between state comes from the fact that it is treated as a problem, something to be escaped, a transitional discomfort suffered on the way to the next stable position. But coming into a stable position is also an enclosure. To settle into one state is to foreclose the other ones. In our post-postmodern existence, liminality rejects being temporal and becomes a permanent condition. Bjørn Thomassen views *permanent liminality* primarily as a danger. The permanence happens when the transition that was meant to bring you back into the known structure simply stops and never completes. The so-called "frozen space" is, in Thomassen's words, "the most fertile terrain possible for tricksters to play their act." Drawing on Agnes Horvath, he warns against the trickster: the uncommitted outsider who thrives in ambiguity, pretending to offer solutions to a crisis while secretly perpetuating conditions of confusion because he is "at home in liminality itself." He isn't wrong about the danger of it, but it also seems that he is just longing for enclosure. What I propose here instead, is not to resist it but to embrace it and become someone who doesn't need the enclosure.

This brings me to the kinetic bias of the liminal. It is easy to assume that this surge of creative clarity is directly triggered by physical motion. Nietzsche famously declared that "only thoughts reached by walking have value," proposing that physical motion directly affects mental stimulation. Sitting in a subway car or walking through an airport terminal feels like a contemporary iteration of that concept. But, if we want to understand liminality as a real operational mechanism rather than a transitional movement, we have to abandon the linear entirely.



Instead of a straight vector from point A to point B, imagine the fold. Points A and B, in this case, aren't opposite ends of a hallway. They're two faces of one folded surface, pressed almost together across a narrow gap. For this example, let A and B stand for identities, the self at A, and whatever self you take yourself to be at B. You are at point A, then you are moving along the

edges of the void until you arrive at point B. Point B, however, is not a new place at all, but the other side of A.



mechanism of the fold

Identity is the reason it has to be shaped this way. On the straight line, B functions as a destination. You leave the old self behind and arrive as another self, but actually, you never meet your identity in the future tense. You can only ever read it retroactively. You can't see who you are becoming while you become it; you can only see it once it has formed. So B does not exist; there was only ever A, and B is just the other side of A. This topological shift can change how we understand identity inside this mechanism. If you view transit as a straight line, you assume point B is a predictable "destination" you are heading toward. But inside the fold, identity is strictly retroactive. You can't predict point B moving along the void. Point B can only ever be understood looking backward, after you have already exited the fold. While you are moving along the fold, point B doesn't exist yet. There is only the void around which the surface bends.

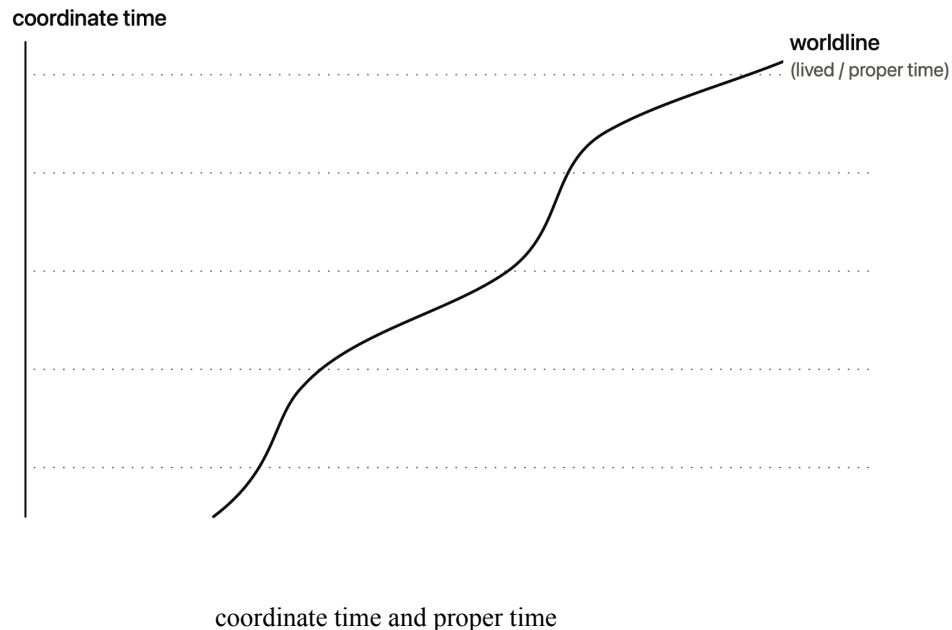
...but what if liminality has nothing to do with movement at all?

If liminality requires kinetic motion, then it also remains dependent on physical infrastructure. If we're trying to move away from physical infrastructure, maybe liminality is not about kinetic experience, but maintaining the state even while still. A good example of this is the Faraday cage, a metal structure blocking all incoming signals. It functions as an artificial zero-point of stillness. The Faraday cage can be used as a model for liminality that can operate without physical motion. It can also show that the core mechanism of the liminal isn't kinetic travel but rather signal loss or disconnection. It is an interruption that cuts off the continuous feed of the external environment, forcing the liminal state. Now, it is dangerously easy to turn the Faraday cage into another static, architectural object. Liminality, however, can't be boiled down to a physical object or an architectural infrastructure.

Every time I try to pin liminality to a spatial coordinate, I end up objectifying it or reducing it to a physical space. Focusing strictly on space, whether through movement or stillness, misses the point of explaining the liminal state. However, what all of the concepts mentioned above have in common, and what I kept missing, is a phenomenon of a place where *time bends*. Bergson explained this well in *Time and Free Will*. He claimed that we tend to spatialize time in order to understand it, which seems to be exactly what I kept doing in this case.

Across *The Backrooms* wikis and Reddit threads, communities return to what users call *achronism* and *spatial-temporal discrepancies*. In these digital narratives, moving across the

liminal doesn't just relocate you in space but causes clock time to collapse. This also makes a concept of achronism a creepypasta, but actually, it might show what all of the prior mentioned mechanisms have in common. In the example of the fold and the void, time collapses as well. In physics terms, this is called *coordinate time* (Bergson identified it as *homogeneous clock time*).



In relativity, *coordinate time* is an external frame assigned to events, a shared grid of synchronized clocks that stamps every moment the same way for everyone. *Proper time* is the time measured by a clock moving along its own path, which can run differently from the coordinate time. The dashed grid represents coordinate time; the worldline is proper time, the lived duration along a single path, which follows its own course through the grid.

Conclusion

All of this comes down to the fact that digital folklore turned the liminal into horror because late-capitalist culture can't tolerate space without function or time without production. Faced with the void, internet lore invented entities to fill up this space with fear. However, stripping away context is not a failure but a liberation from forced legibility. Whether modeled as a Deleuzian smooth space, a topological fold or a Faraday cage, liminality is a shelter from the pre-fixed grid we're living in. Thomassen was right that remaining in the in-between breaks the fixed narrative of a life, but wrong in making it a catastrophe.

To choose permanent liminality is to live an unscripted existence as something cathartic rather than a transitional crisis leading to enclosure. Remaining in this state makes the void transform

into pure generative freedom. What we turned into a horror scenario might just be a radical creative state.

Notes:

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